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Chico Hamilton

Chico Hamilton was born in Los Angeles on September 21, 1921 and has enjoyed a versatile career as a drummer, band leader and producer. He grew up in the fertile music scene of Central Avenue and his band mates included Buddy Collette, Charles Mingus, Dexter Gordon and other future jazz greats. The 1955 Chico Hamilton Quintet created a distinctive sound with its combination of guitar, cello and woodwinds, and helped introduce Eric Dolphy to the jazz world. Chico moved to New York in 1966 and founded a production company that created music for numerous television shows, movies and advertisements. He continues to the present day to be an innovative band leader, percussionist, recording artist and talent scout.

Chico was interviewed in Los Angeles on January 30, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming in Manhattan today, and I'm very, very pleased to have Chico Hamilton with me, who has had a long, illustrious and varied career in music. Would you mind telling me what you're up to in the year 2000?

CH: Sure. I'm just trying to stay alive. No, as a matter of fact we're up to a whole lot of things. The group, my orchestra — I don't refer to it as a band, it's an orchestra, because I think we try to cover all facets of music, not just one direction you know, and not just necessarily under the terminology of even jazz — J-A-Z-Z. I really disapprove of the word myself. I'm in complete accordance with people, with Duke Ellington, Miles Davis, people like that. Why not call it just my music, Chico's music? Duke Ellington's music, Duke Ellington's music. Miles Davis' music, Miles' music. Benny Goodman, Benny Goodman's music. Why label it jazz? Because the word itself has nothing to do with music, from the origin. But anyway, getting back to the two thou, we have tours lined up, European, the Far East, more recordings, and that's about the size of it. You know you can't do any more than that.

MR: Right. Does it make a problem, if you're trying to find a record label to promote your work, they need to put a title to what it is? If you don't want to call it jazz but they do?

CH: Why not just call it music? You know? That's what it is. Because basically, primarily, all we're dealing in is human emotions, is the way one might feel. And I don't expect you to feel the same way that I do about a note or a sound. And it's good because you don't feel the same way because that way we have an abundance of a variety of emotions. Everybody puts their feelings into a mood and it becomes different, which is dynamite. Because if it all sounds the same it would be boring as hell as far as I was concerned.

MR: Right. Did you have trouble finding the right people for this particular group?

CH: I've been very fortunate along those lines. Very, very, very lucky. Because seemingly everyone that becomes involved with what I'm trying to say happens to be at the right place at the right time. So their sound is the sound, becomes the sound of the group. And what keeps the group identity, which has nothing to do with my ego or anything, is the way that I play. It's the rhythm. Every drummer determines what a group is going to sound like, whether you want to acknowledge it or not. He's going to determine whether it's happening or whether it's not happening. And fortunately, since I'm the drummer, I determine what it's going to sound like and what it's going to feel like, irregardless of who's up there on the front line or who's playing the melody.

MR: I would have to agree with that after — I told you I saw Louis Hayes.

CH: Yeah.

MR: He gave that group a certain identity. I mean he's very high energy.

CH: I can dig that.

MR: And active I guess. If you can be real honest, and don't worry about your ego, can you tell me where do you fit in the line of drummers in innovation and in your music? I mean I don't know if I asked that question very well but—

CH: Well I don't know. I'm being very honest. First of all it's totally impossible for two drummers to play alike, because of the physical aspect. One might have long arms, one might have short arms. And if you have short arms that means that you have to sit closer to your instrument. If you have long arms you sit back, that type of thing, for reach. And just the space between makes a difference in the sound you're going to get, or the touch you're going to acquire to get the sound. I don't sound like anybody else, and I don't know of anybody who sounds like me. Here again, it becomes very personal. It all depends on what you like and what you don't like. You see, I think that anybody, drummers, that try to play, is doing a hell of a job, is contributing to something. So the old adage about "hey give the drummer some" that's the bottom line. But I don't know, I just do what I do. And Louis Hayes does what he does, Max does what he does, Kenny Clarke did what he did, Jo Jones did what he did, Sonny Greer. All of them. Elvin Hayes, Buddy Rich, Gene Krupa. They're all — that's how broad and beautiful this whole thing is in regards to playing or approaching that instrument. So it all depends on whose beat you dig.

MR: It's usually left to the non-musicians I guess to try to put down, this guy was influenced by this guy, influenced by this guy, and so forth. Sometimes it's true and sometimes maybe not.

CH: Well I believe that every living human being is a musician. Some are learned and some are not. Those who are learned become fantastic musicians. They become players. Then there are those who become fantastic listeners, which — you can't tell anyone how to listen to music. But you can tell someone how to play or how you would like them to play, but you can't tell them how to listen to music. So in order to listen to music, that calls for some musicianship. This is an innate thing that we all are all blessed with. Because I believe that music is one of God's wills and God's will will be done. You can quote me on that.

MR: It's a good quote. A spiritual aspect of the craft, has that always been with you?

CH: I think so, I think so. Because it's just through the grace of God, man, that I'm even here today. Even as a kid coming up, I used to shine shoes with a shoeshine box to make enough money so that — I bought my first set of drums shining shoes. So that was helpful from the man upstairs. And I sincerely believe that it is God's will about music. Because also there's no anger in music. There's no prejudice in music. So it's got to be — something's got to be happening. As a matter of fact, can you imagine what this world would be like without music?

MR: No. I wouldn't want to think about that.

CH: So see what I mean? And my instrument has been more devastating than bombs. You know to strike the fear into a human being. Hitler proved that when he had this march you know. In the early years of Africa the drums — hey you heard them, boom, boom, right? And the Indians — boom, boom, boom, boom you know? Hey man. As a matter of fact you could take, right here in New York, believe me, trust me, you could take a one hundred piece orchestra, or one hundred piece marching band, and let them march down Fifth Avenue, right? And people would say oh yeah, okay, that's just the band, right? But you take one drummer, one man, or one kid with a drum and let him walk down Fifth Avenue playing it, and it will stop traffic. It will stop the world. Look at that, right? They don't know whether he's an idiot or what. And it will stop traffic. You take a kid to a music store, right? And just let him walk in the music store and the first thing he will do, he will go over to where the drums are and touch them. He won't go to the trombones, he won't go to the trumpets, he won't go to the saxophones. It even outdoes guitars. He'll go over to the drums.

MR: It's impossible for them to walk by it without—

CH: Without hitting it or touching it.

MR: Right.

CH: It's the skin you love to touch, which is the name of my book I'm writing. So anyway, I just wanted to get that in there.

MR: Yeah, look forward to that. It's a long process isn't it, writing a book?

CH: Oh yeah. Yeah it is. It's a strange process for the simple reason that the potential publishers want me to write about all the dirty things I know, the bad things I know about people. And I refuse to do this.

MR: You know I've noticed there's a real fraternity amongst musicians, that no one that I've talked to has offered those kinds of things. And I'm not really after them but even, like we were talking about Benny Goodman, who apparently was a real difficult person, but the worst anybody's ever said about him is, "Oh that Benny, what a character." People don't want to —

CH: Well people are people. And just because you happened to be blessed so that you can play an instrument and play it well doesn't mean that if you're a dirty dude man, if you're a bad guy, you're still a bad guy. That does not necessarily mean that you're going to play bad. You understand?

MR: Yeah.

CH: So people — we do bring our personalities into what we do in our playing. Somewhere down the line it shows up. But I would say overall there's a camaraderie among musicians as opposed to, for instance you take actors. There's no camaraderie among actors and it's for a simple reason. It's because a musician, in order to make music, we have to play together. Ensemble, right, whatever. An actor, there's only one part. If you got the part I ain't working. Out of work.

MR: Well you grew up in a pretty musical atmosphere.

CH: Yes I did.

MR: It was Central Avenue in Los Angeles?

CH: Yeah.

MR: And I've read some interesting things about that. At what point in your youth did you think that maybe you could make a living as a musician? Tough question, huh?

CH: No, it's a good question. But I never thought about it. I never thought about whether or not I could not make my living playing music, making music, or — at this stage of the game I'm fortunate enough to make music. But playing music — I've always, I've been making my living ever since I was about twelve, thirteen years old, playing drums. So I've never had an occasion to even — plus the fact I've been fortunate enough to — I've done nothing but music all my life. When I stopped shining shoes as a kid, that was it. Boom. Straight ahead. I haven't looked back, that type of thing. And that's an honorable profession also, shining shoes. But anyway I never had any doubts.

MR: Well that's a great way to put it, that you never thought you couldn't.

CH: Plus I learned very early in life — I learned how to live off of five dollars a day, five dollars a minute, five dollars a second, five dollars a week, five dollars a year.

MR: That sounds like a book right there.

CH: Yeah. Well you learn that. Which is cool.

MR: I had a couple —

CH: Go ahead, ask me anything.

MR: Jack Kelson said he had a couple of little interesting anecdotes or remembrances of those times, and he said something about in grammar school where a band person would go around and everybody would get to play something. And when it got to you you'd like wipe everybody out. Is that true?

CH: Jack happens to be my oldest, dearest, best friend. And you know what? I just talked to him the other day. We have never had a cross word, and we've known each other since we were eight years old. Yeah.

MR: That's great.

CH: As a matter of fact he's totally responsible I guess for me getting into music because his folks gave him a clarinet when he was around that age. So he being my best friend, I had to have a clarinet. And we were so poor though, we couldn't afford, you could get a clarinet from the school for two dollars a semester. And it took us, man it must have took me about a whole semester to get two dollars together. But anyway, getting back to that, Lionel Hampton was very popular at that time you know. And Lionel used to play, he'd go around with his sticks off the bandstand, he'd play on the floor, he'd play on the walls, he'd play all over the place. So I used to imitate him.

MR: I see.

CH: That why, kids would just go crazy. I'm playing shit but I'd just go play.

MR: Yeah. You're playing the room, right? That's great. He also said something — oh he had a nice quote about you. He said, "Chico to me is in a sense like Duke Ellington. He plays his music using any player, any group of instruments. It doesn't matter what it is he puts his own stamp on it."

CH: That's true. That's true. You know, being a band leader, or a leader of a group, it's more than just having a name or creating a name or building a name. It's being able to — knowing when to, how to present something. Knowing — I have an innate sense about well knowing talent, hearing talent, and seeing talent. And I know, see it takes two things, two very important things to reach a stage where you can make music, and that's patience and fortitude. This I learned very early, in my early youth. So I had the patience to watch a talent develop. And since I'm in the driver's seat, since I'm there keeping time for him, I can guide them. I can play to their weakness and help them become strong. So knowing

that whatever talent that they might have, there's always a resentment, a tremendous resentment when someone is different. I've been considered, okay I'm an innovator, I know that. Whether that's good or bad or indifferent, but it's a very lonely life, because you're constantly — I'm past the stage of trying to please. I don't please anybody. I play music for music's sake. There should be no substitute for not playing your best, playing whatever you play. You play your best. And this is my whole thing, my whole being. Whatever I do — I might sound good, bad or indifferent, hey but I'm doing my best. So whenever you're different it's going to be ten to one it's not going to dig you. For an old colloquial expression "dig" means like or dislike. But knowing or feeling hey, man, nobody — like they wanted me to fire Eric Dolphy. They wanted me to fire Charles Lloyd. Larry Coryell. People like that. I said later for that. Straight ahead, you know? And what happened? These guys turned out to be young geniuses.

MR: And the list of people that you have, as you said, had patience with, is really quite impressive. And as a youth, you must have played some interesting gigs on the way up.

CH: Oh yeah.

MR: Strip shows? That kind of stuff? Whatever came along?

CH: Hey man you know, speaking of that, we had this — there was a band. There was a man, a gentleman in L.A., his name was Meyers. And we used to call him Old Man Meyers. Jack and I used to play with him in his orchestra. He had I think three sons, one played piano, one played trumpet and one played I think bass if I remember. And he played trumpet. And Jack and I. And man, we used to play places where, roadhouses, where it was an all-colored orchestra, you know, which was a big deal, right? That type of thing. Anyway we'd play, well I'm just trying to think of places, incidentally we'd get paid, right? Seventy-five cents. I mean like half a dollar and a quarter. And we'd have a kitty. And we'd travel maybe 35, 40, 50 miles to these roadhouse places.

MR: To make seventy-five cents.

CH: To make seventy-five cents plus the kitty, which would maybe come to a dollar, you know that type of thing. But anyway, playing, it was all part of it. It was all part of playing music, it was all part of being a musician, it was all part of, you know. One thing led to another, the experience you had over here helped you with the experience on the next gig, that type of thing. As a matter of fact what did you ask me? I forgot? What was the original question?

MR: I was asking about just, you know, paying dues, and interesting kind of gigs that would come up.

CH: Man listen, we played, I recall years ago man we played a rodeo.

MR: You played a rodeo?

CH: Yeah. And we were on a flatbed truck, right? And man a bull, one of those charging bulls got loose and he jumped up on that. Terrible man. It was funny stuff.

MR: Funny to talk about it now.

CH: You could just imagine seeing that you know? And I've had a lot of beautiful experiences playing with various — I think the most rewarding in a sense, experience that I've had, I spent about fifteen years playing for singers, nothing but singers. And I was with Lena Horne for eight years. And during that period with Lena Horne it took me out of the realm of just being a musician. It took me into show biz. That's a big difference between a musician, a jazz musician, and show biz people, the whole thing. It just opened up a whole new world for me. And through that eight years we played, I played for some of the most notable people of the times during that era. And we played all over the world, things like that. And I became — her husband, Lennie Hayton, he became my mentor. And I learned a hell of a lot about music from this man. This man was a genius and a gentleman, had class, he taught me how to play chess, he taught me how to eat a lobster, things like that. Taught me how to drink cognac. No he was a good dude and we were friends. He and Luther Henderson and Billy Strayhorn were my whatever — I was the kid, they embraced me. And it was very rewarding because those things that I learned are still with me today. I try to in turn bestow this upon other younger players that come up that are on the scene today. Because be a professional you know?

MR: It's not as easy as it sounds.

CH: No it's not. But if you think in terms of being a professional, hey, you can get just like a doctor, a lawyer or anybody else. You are a professional musician.

MR: What was the racial atmosphere like between musicians in the late 40s in L.A.?

CH: Racial? What do you mean?

MR: Were blacks and whites allowed to play together?

CH: Oh yeah. As a matter of fact, oh yeah. Out in L.A. anyway. I don't know about the rest of the country because I didn't leave L.A. until I was about 21 I think, something like that. But to my knowledge, as a matter of fact, one of my early groups, when Buddy Collette left the group, Paul Horn joined the group, right? And I was billed as Chico Hamilton and his All White Orchestra.

MR: Is that right? Carson Smith?

CH: Carson Smith, Paul Horn, John Pisano and Fred Katz. Oh man I went through a whole lot of shit. But we went through — I don't even want to talk about that stuff, because it's not worth it man, it's not worth it.

MR: Well much has been made of the sound of that group. I mean that was like this much of your career really.

CH: Yeah.

MR: A few, six, five or six years.

CH: Yeah.

MR: That sound with the cello and pianoless. Did that come about from sitting down and thinking let's find something different here? Or was it a more practical—

CH: Originally the group was going to be French horn, John Graas, he was the number one French horn player on the West Coast at that time when I formed the group. The group was intact with Buddy and Jim Hall, and Carson. And Buddy and I came up musically together. Cars and I were with Gerry together, and Jim Hall was just a stroke of luck. He needed a gig and he heard that I was organizing, putting a group together. Because he was stacking music in a music store at that time. He wasn't even playing. And the day of the first rehearsal, if I remember correctly, John Graas had a heart attack and died. And that night, I was doing a thing with Fred. Fred Katz was with me when I was with Lena. And I told Fred my plight. And we got to talking. So Fred said, "Well, Chic, if you like I'll come over." And I said, "Dynamite." So that's how it happened. And I go on record, you know it's also in my book, the fact that like that group and the Gerry Mulligan Quartet, that group, we just happened to be the right people in the right place at the right time. It was no stroke of genius. We just happened to be — Chet, Gerry, myself and Bob were like — it all started in my living room. The same room that the Gerry Mulligan Quartet started with, my quintet rehearsed in the same room, the living room of my house in L.A. So I just think it just happened to be in the right place at the right time. Critics, historians or people, everyone wants to make something — genius this — that's bullshit. This is how it happened. So it's just like I did a solo one time in a studio where we were recording. And I dropped my stick. This is the truth man. Somebody — and it was recorded, right? Somebody transcribed this and made a drum solo out of it and made a big record out of it.

MR: And even had the part where the stick fell.

CH: So anyway, but I really feel that, sincerely, that we just happened to be the right guys at the right place. Same thing I feel about Miles and his groups. Or any group that is put together and the sound is there and the feeling is there, they're the right people for the right — you know. And that's why you ask me about that reunion CD. You can't go back man. That's 30 years. And we went on tour, right? And it wasn't the same. All us guys 30 years older, and it just — the moments weren't there. You can't go back, that's what I feel anyway. Nostalgia is fantastic, but in your emotions, that's all we've got is memories, you know, from one moment to the next. And you try to make as many pleasant moments as you possibly can have, because hey when you look back that's what

you want to look at. But you can't capture feelings. It's over. So you've got to look forward. Hey turn the corner, turn the page.

MR: It's almost like to recreate what that was you would have had to set aside all your experiences from then on to try to get back to that.

CH: Exactly. It's not putting Fred or Buddy down or putting anybody down, it's just that I'm a different person. And my newest, the "Timely" album, is living proof of hey, you might not like it as well but hey what the hell, it's what I'm doing now. Somebody likes it because it's been moving. And I'm still doing it and I'm still playing all over the world, which is cool. But it's like how many Benny Goodman bands really did it? How many Count Basie bands did it? How many Duke Ellington bands did it? Regardless of the personnel, with very few changes during that era. But it couldn't — you know, after Prez left Basie? As far as I'm concerned, nobody filled that chair. Even as well as Illinois played, as well as Lockjaw played, you know, whoever was soloing.

MR: Buddy Tate.

CH: Buddy — well even Buddy.

MR: Well he filled the other fellas' chair. Even that was different.

CH: Yeah. It was different from Herschel you know? See that's another thing about young players today. I was very fortunate man because I came up at the right time. I came up at the right time, and these young dudes today don't — it's totally impossible because you don't have the bands. There's nothing like a big band — experience in playing with a big band or listening to a big band, or breathing with a big band. There's nothing like that experience. And thank goodness man, one thing I would say about the jazz educators throughout the universities, the schools, fortunately man, they're doing everything they can to keep it going. Because outside of that, nothing. And unfortunately because the media won't accept, you know, T.V. has done more to hurt the big bands, the big, broad sound, than it has to help them. T.V. has hurt jazz. Can you imagine if T.V. had devoted one-third of the time that they devote to this other kind of music? This what they refer to music. You know, people would still be into this form of music — I would say "form" of music.

MR: Right.

CH: In esssence, a family that listens to jazz together stays together.

MR: Ooh. That's a good statement.

CH: That's heavy, right?

MR: Yeah. In the '60s, rock was obviously very prevalent. Did the popular music of the day affect your thinking, your own personal style?

CH: During that era when we came up, which was in the '50s, in the middle of the '50s, fundamentally all we were trying to do man is play in tune. Play some good music and play in tune. That's basically all we were looking forward to doing. Because you had to — the whole thing just turned lopsided. Saxophone players — the only time they could get a job recording in the studio is they would put some gloves on and play. You know? And that's pretty bad. You know what kind of sound they're going to get, right? And that's all the kind of people that they were recording, were letting record. All of a sudden man, when the CPAs and attorneys took over and made this music into a business, that's when the change came about. You know? Well just look, what was it this year, last year, the Grammy so-called thing, right?

MR: Right, the Grammy so-called thing.

CH: Man, you know, they won't even put — they won't even let the jazz artists have any air time.

MR: Right. Previously awards given out.

CH: Right. Previously awards given out. Do you believe that?

MR: Yeah, I've heard this point before and you're backing up a couple of people who have said that some of the record companies used to be run by musicians. And then that kind of ended and things changed.

CH: Yup. Well it became a business, you know, a super business. And we're drinking apple juice.

MR: That's right. In 1966 you started a production company?

CH: Yeah. I was doing commercials. It was very successful. Very successful. As a matter of fact I would say during that part of the 60s some of the best music on television was the commercial music, because they were using jazz, a lot of jazz.

MR: Can you mention a few commercials that—

CH: That I did? Sure. The first time IBM ever went on the air they had three minute spots, which was considered a feature. I did all the music for IBM. I did the music for Revlon, Chrysler, Volkswagen. My first commercial that I ever did was when cigarettes were on the air, Spring Cigarettes. [sings] Spring is better. I did that. I had that whole campaign. Ivory Soap [scats] I did that. It was very successful. I reached a point though that I got tapped out. I reached a point that I was doing everything for the money. It didn't matter what it was. And you start pigeon-holing things. And one day man I was at a meeting, a big meeting, and not only was I the composer and arranger but I was the producer as well. And as a producer man, I'm handling accounts at that time, maybe a quarter of a million dollars account, that kind of money that was going to be spent in regards to that. But I was at this one meeting, and I was there maybe about several hours. And at the end

of the meeting they said, "Chico, we'll call you." Just like that. So I got up and I walked to the elevator and I punched the elevator, and as I was waiting for the elevator to come up, all of a sudden the realization just hit me, just don't call us, we'll call you. And man I just said screw this. And that's it. I stopped. I came home, came back to my office, I told my wife I said, "Hey, listen Babes, I've had it. I'm going to start doing what I'm supposed to be doing again. I'm going to start playing again." And I started.

MR: All right. So how long a span of years was that?

CH: Well I started, let's see, from '66 'till up in the '70s, up until the '80s maybe. It was long.

MR: Wow. That's a high pressure world to be in, isn't it.

CH: Oh yeah. Man I learned how to drink in the daytime. You know, the three martini lunch. I had never drank before in my life in the daytime you know? I learned that.

MR: Learned how to schmooze?

CH: It's unbelievable man. But anyway, it was good though. I made a lot of dough. But what good is the dough when you kind of lose something.

MR: Where do you write? Do you write at the piano? Do you sit and—

CH: No I write at the piano, at the keyboard. I'm not a very good piano player but—

MR: It gives you enough to hear the chords and conceive of a melody and so forth.

CH: Um hum.

MR: Well you have been recording for —

CH: Umpteen years.

MR: Since 1941 "Slim and Slam."

CH: Man, Slim Gaillard was a genius. Was a pure genius. He was a drummer out there. And trombone player and scat singer by the name of Leo Watson. He was a genius. These guys, anything they touched, they made music with it. Slim Gaillard was unbelievable, unbelievable, unbelievable. He was fascinating. And you know Slam [Stewart], arco. But yeah that was — I was about 14, 15, 16, something like that.

MR: Yeah. That's wild. And everything of course, recordings back in those days, you were in a room and everybody played together.

CH: You didn't go into the studio then unless you were at the peak of your profession. You didn't rehearse in the studio, you were ready. When you went into the studio that was it. As a matter of fact, I made an album, I think it was — I don't know what the name of it was, I think it was either Capitol or some label, called "Reaching for the Top." It was a new method whereas we did at least ten tunes, ten things, ten arrangements. We didn't stop because it was continuous. You couldn't stop because if you did you had to go right back to the top and start all over again. And we had to play everything. We played that whole album without any repeats or without stopping. Which is cool you know. Well

that's the way it used to be. And then being a producer too, doing commercials, time was money. And by the time I'd get ready to go to the studio to do a spot, I was ready, we were ready. I'd rehearse before time. And when we'd go in there, boom. One or two takes, that's it. That's another thing, when you're recording, I don't care if a note is wrong. If the emotional aspect, if the feeling is there, the overall feeling, and somebody has a moment, a high moment, hey man that's it, that's the take. Because here again, regardless whether it sounds good or bad or indifferent, that's you. To go back in, to edit, that's cheating as far as I'm concerned. That's not right.

MR: Yeah. Take this eight bars and put it in.

CH: Yeah.

MR: You're going to always know that that was doctored.

CH: Oh yeah. Well the only person that did that that I approve of doing that and it came out masterfully was Gil Evans with Miles' things, with "Miles Ahead."

MR: That was some —

CH: Oh yeah, well he had to because that was—

MR: Very challenging music.

CH: Unbelievable man, it's hip. Some of the hippest stuff ever, ever, ever.

MR: The list of people that have been beside you is astounding. What was it like to work with Mingus?

CH: Charlie. Charles. Well Charlie and I, we grew up together. We came up together. And we sort of had a love-hate relationship type of thing. I remember one time we were in Oakland, California, and we were with Floyd Ray's band. And I was doing a drum solo. And man, Charlie came out, went backstage and got a hammer, and came out and started hammering the bandstand.

MR: Was he playing in time?

CH: But Mingus, Charles was always like that. He and my wife used to go to Sunday school together so that's how long we've been knowing each other, you know, that kind of thing. Anyway, Charlie was a very misunderstood dude period. As a youngster, as a young man and as a grown man, and even as a musician. Because we all more or less had the same beginning, same schooling, same thoughts. And one thing that we all had in common was the fact that we all dug music. And there was never any doubt in any of our minds that we weren't musicians, even then.

MR: Well he certainly had the fortitude, maybe he was a little short on the patience thing that you mentioned.

CH: Well Charles was pretty hip too man. He'd do a lot of things just to see what—

MR: To get a reaction?

CH: To get a reaction. He was just psycho. He knew what you were going to do, how you were going to react.

MR: The Andy Kaufman of jazz, huh? Just to get a rise out of people. If I was to pick out —

CH: A tune on that?

MR: Just to play a little bit.

CH: You want to play one of mine?

MR: Yeah, I'd love to.

CH: What kind of groove do you want?

MR: I want something pretty funky.

CH: Something pretty funky? Did we do anything funky on there? It's not funky but it's really charming. It's called "Mr. Andrew J. Caddick." I don't know what track that is.

MR: I'll have to look in there I think.

CH: Yeah, you've got your glasses. I wrote this for my manager who has been with me for the last, over ten years, young dude.

MR: There it is.

CH: Andrew Caddick.

MR: Okay.

[audio interlude]

MR: I love that bass sound. It's beautiful.

CH: It's just bass and guitar and drums.

[audio interlude]

CH: And it's got that little flow man, it swings.

MR: Beautiful. Can you recall when you first brought this to the group, how much describing — for instance, that guitar thing. Did you describe to your guitar player I want something kind of ethereal or did you let them try things and guide them?

CH: No not really, I didn't have to tell Cary what to do. No.

MR: That's why you have him, right?

CH: Exactly. I just wrote the melody and that was all, just blow. And his voicing of his chords, that's his, that's Cary's thing. It's a complete departure from everything else on the album, but it's [scats] a simple little melody.

MR: That's nice.

CH: See you can't — there's no substitute for simplicity and continuity. It's just like patience and fortitude, really. But simplicity and continuity, these are the things that are very effective. These are the things that are haunting, these are the things that you remember, your brain retains.

MR: Yes. It's singable. It's lovely. Well that's great.

CH: That's just an example. That's a good album man.

MR: All right. I'll be checking it out. And do you hear artists out there these days that you think are doing anything new?

CH: That's difficult for me to say because first of all, [sings] don't get around much anymore. But if I do I'm on the outskirts of town. But just listening to the records or CD's, or things, unfortunately no. Because I don't know why Blue Note wants to recreate Art Blakey's sound. You can't. There's no players that can — they can duplicate it but the feeling's not there. So why not let these new, young artists do their own thing? You know what I mean? Give them their own voice. And therefore that question is difficult. Now I teach, I teach at the New School. I teach two classes down there, two courses. One is Rhythm Analysis and another one is Ensemble Improvisation. And there's a lot of potential, talented young people down there. Hopefully every opportunity I have to confront them I try to instill in them, hey, be yourself. Do your thing. Don't try to play like so-and-so and so-and-so. You play what you feel. Use your ideas. Use your thoughts. It'll happen. So hopefully some of them will develop. But overall man, it's like the people who originated this music, who originated this style, who originated this form, there's no duplication. If a man shows you you can be like, you can play a lot, be like that, but it's not the same. It's just like Wynton Marsalis with the —

MR: Lincoln Center Orchestra.

CH: Lincoln Center Orchestra. Duke, Duke, Duke, Duke. Ain't nothing Dukish about what he's doing as far as I'm concerned. It's not that — musically they play beautifully. But as far as I'm concerned they don't swing. Unfortunately I have to put it on the rhythm section. They play the same charts that Duke played, and there's a world of difference, it's the personnel.

MR: Sometimes I think it might have something to do with —

CH: It becomes so sterile as far as I'm concerned. It's too clean.

MR: Too clean, yeah. Too much in the amplification. If you start making the bass too loud it affects the way the music was conceived I think.

CH: It's like how can you duplicate Trane? How can you duplicate Bird or Sweets or Prez or Diz? You know it's just like these so-called radio stations. They call themselves jazz stations. Now I purposely don't listen to them, but I listened to them all last week, right? Because I was home. And the whole length of time I was listening to them, the whole week, I think they played one Charlie Parker record, and one Dizzy Gillespie record. A whole week. Never Chico Hamilton.

MR: Yeah, I was going to say, did you get in there.

CH: Never. They don't play my music. Maybe they've got something against me. I was a bad guy or something, I talked about them or something. Who cares. But they do a lot to dictate what people will listen to, and they also turn a lot of people off, especially a lot of young people won't listen to jazz, because they don't want to hear what these people really think jazz is. That's something to think about, right?

MR: Yeah. Somehow we've managed to make jazz —

CH: A dirty name.

MR: A little inaccessible.

CH: Yup.

MR: Hard to like. You know you have to go to a lot of work to —

CH: Well I have a philosophy on that too. A reason why, the whyness or why of that. It's during the groupie period in this country, when the groupies and people all decided, hey, they're going to cop out and just become whatever. You know, during Woodstock, what do you call it.

MR: In the 60s era, the —

CH: The dropouts or whatever.

MR: The hippies?

CH: Hippies, okay. See hippies was — hip.

MR: Hip used to mean hip.

CH: But the reason for that, I mean what I'm getting at, and this is a funny philosophy but when these people start turning off, the first things they turn off was their parents. Old fashioned, old hat. So in turning their parents off they turned off everything the parents dug, everything they liked, jazz was one of them. Jazz was one of the things, hey I don't like it because my parents like it, so hey, I'm going to go over here and hear this other shit. You want to bleep that off or keep that in. But anyway, so that's where the division began. They didn't like it because their parents liked it. And from there it just got bigger and bigger and bigger and bigger and bigger, in the meantime this other thing was thrust, thrust, thrust, thrust, next thing you know, they had a program on television last week, I guess it was sometime last week, called "American Music" or something, where they gave out awards.

MR: Oh yeah, the American Music Awards.

CH: Man that was some of the —

MR: Sorriest.

CH: Hey man I'm not bitter, I'm not envious, I'm not jealous, hey man it's straight ahead for everybody. I mean the more the better. But man I didn't believe some of that stuff. I did not believe what these people considered talent. I did not believe what these people

considered good. Mediocrity is king now man. You know? And unfortunately man, young people don't have an opportunity to decide what is good and what is bad and what is different. They don't even have a culture. They have not — I mean at least we developed a culture so that we could look back and say hey well so-and-so did so-and-so and so-and-so is responsible for this. Hey well man, that's a dynamite chair. Wow, it was designed, and we have this. What they have is — how outlandish can you be? How funky can you be? Shit. Don't let me get started man. I'm not bitter man. It's cool, man.

MR: I object most to being yelled at by the music. I see these guys back and forth on the stage like yelling. It bothers me. What are you so mad about?

CH: There is nothing new about rap. They acknowledge it as music now. This is music. But there's nothing new about that. In the days of the kings, queens, King Arthur, the roundtable, they had the court jester, that's what he did, he rapped. Nobody sang the songs, a melodic song. That's all they did was rap. Then when I was a kid, a young dude, we had a thing we called "playing the dozens," that was rapping. The dirty dozens you know, when you talked about each other's mother and things like that. That was rap. Because you made things rhyme you know. So I'm completely astounded at the amount of monies that this generates, the generator. It's just like the amount of monies that they have generated with the so-called American Music kind of thing — the kind of money that these people make — not make but are given. Whew. Man. Seemingly some of them would do something good with it, hopefully. You know? I don't see why they wouldn't — you know the kind of money, like can you imagine recording man. They spend a whole year in the studio to make one track. Hundreds of thousands of dollars man, for one track. It's unbelievable.

MR: Yeah it is unbelievable. Too many toys to play with I think.

CH: Unbelievable man.

MR: Do you think technology has been a positive influence on recording or not?

CH: Technology is dynamite. I'm all for it. But it's the people, it's the hands that are behind, that are controlling the technology. I think they should grow as well as the technical aspects of technology. Does that make sense?

MR: Yeah, sure.

CH: You know? I think the hands — you know it's just like there is no substitute for breath blowing instrument. You can put your hand on a key and hold that note for two weeks if you want to. But you can't hold a note breathing for two weeks. So holding that note, breathing that breath when you do decide to breathe, it comes under the heading of phrasing. And what that phrasing is all about is what your heart, your head, your ears, your soul feels and hears. Not how long that sustaining power is, you know?

MR: Yeah. It's like that bass player who played your melody.

CH: Exactly.

MR: You can breathe with that thing and see it.

CH: Exactly.

MR: Absolutely.

CH: So the technology of the technicians is fantastic but the technicians themselves should become as contemporary as the instruments that they are playing with. Does that make sense?

MR: Yes, absolutely.

CH: Because it's just like a God damn engineer man, destroyed the drum in the studio, they destroyed the natural sound of the drum. They've got it so padded, they've got it this — the drum doesn't sound like a drum anymore. It doesn't sound like — whoever's playing, you don't hear their sound. They all sound alike [scats].

MR: Well you have some great philosophies and it's refreshing—

CH: It's time to get out of Dodge, right?

MR: It's time to get out of Dodge. It's refreshing to hear your ideas and interesting that you're a forward thinking person.

CH: I sort of pride myself on it. I mean at least being contemporary. I don't know what's going to happen tomorrow but at least, hey man, I'm willing to give everybody a shot. Really. In regards to hey, well, maybe I don't dig it but hey it's got to be five o'clock somewhere.

MR: All right.

CH: You know what I mean? It's just like when you take a drink at ten o'clock in the morning, right, it's five o'clock somewhere in the world. I enjoyed this man, so hey, listen man, I want to come up to the school man and play. I want to bring my group up and play. I want to get something a little different in from what you're going to hear every day.

MR: All right. I'll check into it.

CH: Dynamite.

MR: Thanks for your time.

CH: Hey, it's cool.

MR: Appreciate it.